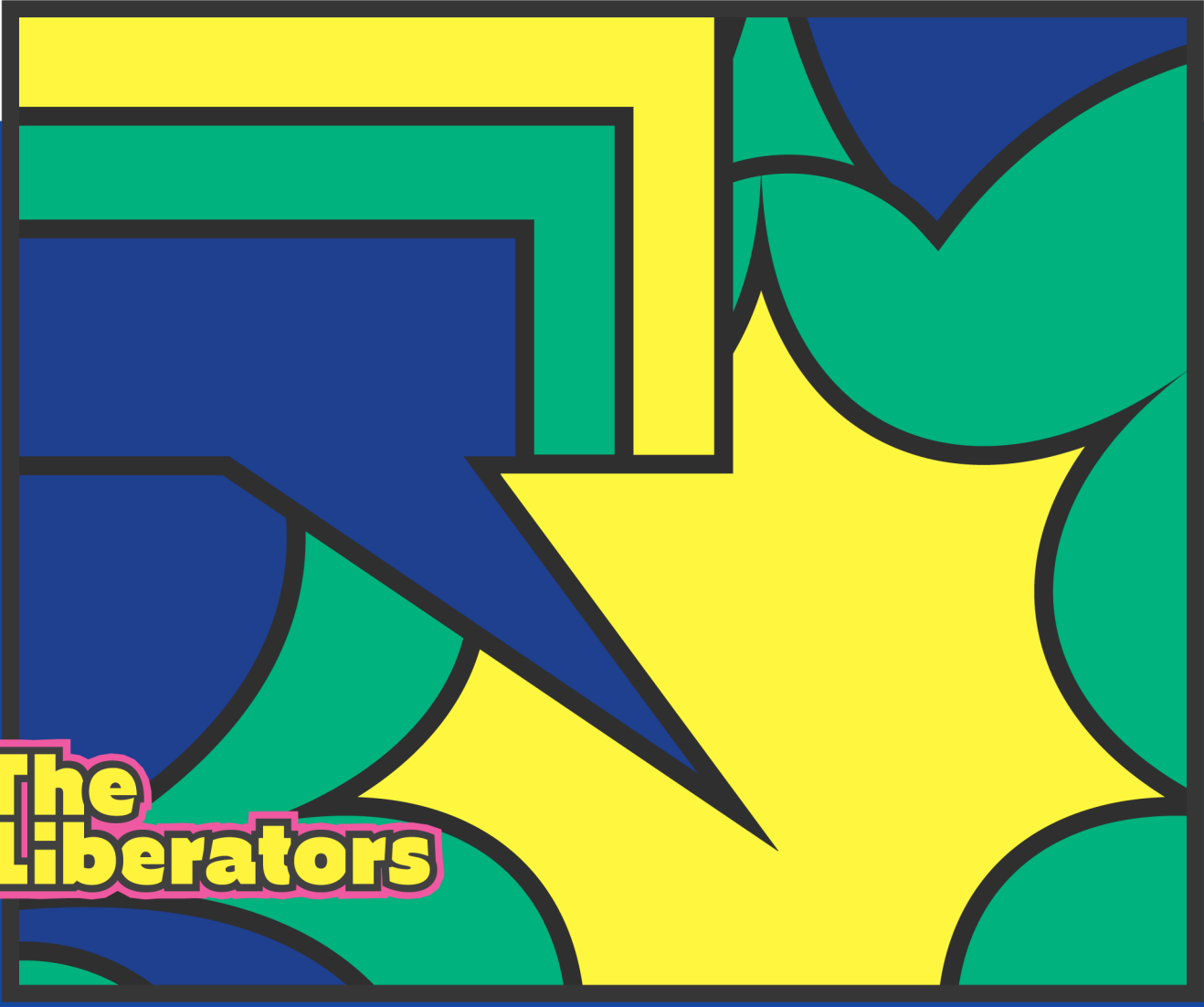


Deepening Understanding Of Readings

How to interactively deepen understanding of readings with students with the Liberating Structures Conversation Cafe & What, So What, Now What



**The
Liberators**

How to prepare



As an educator, one of your tasks is to help students make sense of what they read and deepen their understanding of key ideas. But it can be challenging to move beyond surface-level summaries and keep students meaningfully engaged.

This exercise guide offers two interactive formats to help students explore and unpack readings together. It is designed for:

- 5–50 students
- 30–45 minutes
- Classroom setting

To prepare:

- Optimize the learning space so students can move around and into groups easily.
- Prepare a surface to collect students' outputs, such as a board or a window.
- Provide paper, sticky notes, and pens for each student.
- To quickly regain attention at the end of the short rounds, a high tone helps cut through noise. We often use Tingsha Bells.

Attribution

This guide was created by **Barry Overeem**, **Christiaan Verwijs**, **Prof. Margaret Anne–Storey**, and **Prof. Daniel Russo**.

Liberating Structures are created by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. Their mission is to unleash and involve everyone. Learn more at <https://liberatingstructures.com>.



 30 min

Option 1: Conversation Café



In a **Conversation Café**, small groups of students engage in a structured conversation to deepen their understanding of a reading, concept, or topic.

Preparation

- Select a reading, concept, or topic that benefits from collaborative sense-making. This could be a paper or chapter that students read as part of their preparations, or a personal experience with a topic.
- Arrange the room so that students can sit in small groups of 4–5 students. Each group should be able to have a focused conversation without overhearing the other groups too much.

Steps

- **2 min** Ask students to form small groups and pick one person in each group to host the conversation. The host keeps track of time, guides the process, and participates in the conversation.
- **2 min** Present the topic and give students a moment to reflect individually and silently. A question like “What was surprising, unclear, or familiar to you about [topic]” is useful for readings, whereas a question like “What has been your experience with [topic]?” is useful for personal experience. This reflection step ensures that students already have something in mind.
- **5 min** Invite students to take turns sharing their reflections for about one minute each. The host ensures that only one person speaks at a time, without interruption.
- **5 min** Ask students to take another round to share observations or reactions to what they heard. The host ensures that there is no discussion yet, just listening and adding perspectives.
- **(10–15 min)** Invite students to have an open, lively conversation within their small group, building on each other's ideas and perspectives. They can capture insights if they want.
- **5 min** Ask students to briefly share their main insights or takeaways within their small group. The host ensures that only one person speaks at a time, without interruption.
- **(5–10 min)** Debrief with the full group. What stood out? What new understanding emerged? What questions remain?

Tips

- Encourage students to refer back to the reading during the conversation to ground their points.
- Remind hosts to protect equal airtime, especially in the first rounds.
- Consider collecting key insights on a board to make patterns across groups visible.
- A talking object can help avoid interruptions. Only the person holding the object can speak, and only they can give it to someone else.



30 min

Option 2: What, So What, Now What



In **What, So What, Now What**, students reflect on an experience, activity, or reading in three simple steps. The structure helps them move from describing what happened to making sense of it, and finally to identifying concrete next steps.

Preparation

- Select a reading to reflect on. This works best when students have something concrete to draw from.
- Arrange the room so students can work in small groups (around 4 –5 people).

Steps

- **2 min** Briefly set the stage. You will be running an interactive exercise to deepen understanding of readings.
- **2 min** Invite students to form small groups of 4 – 5 people.
- **(5–8 min)** Ask students to take a piece of paper. Invite them to silently and individually list the key facts, insights, and points of confusion the reading triggered (**_What?_**). Then, have them share their notes first in pairs, followed by a discussion in groups of four.
- **(5–8 min)** Invite them to silently and individually reflect on what stands out, why it matters, and what it might mean in a broader context (**_So What?_**). Then, have them share their reflections first in pairs, followed by a discussion in groups of four.
- **(5–8 min)** Invite them to silently and individually identify how they will use the insights from the reading, for example, how it might influence their thinking, approach, or future readings (**_Now What?_**). Encourage them to note one or two concrete actions. Then, have them share their ideas first in pairs, followed by a discussion in groups of four.
- **(5–8 min)** Finally, invite students to briefly share what they learned and what they will do next, either within their group or with the full class.

Tips

- Keep the phases clearly separated. Students tend to jump to conclusions too quickly, skipping the "What" step.
- Encourage specific, concrete actions in the final step. Vague intentions won't lead to much change.
- Capture key insights or actions visibly to reinforce learning.

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